CHOCOLATE PUDDING

MAKES	ACTIVE TIME	REST	TOTAL TIME
1.02 kg of pudding, 4 to 6 servings	**25 min**	**chilled until cold and set**	**25 min plus chilling**

INGREDIENTS

420 ml	Whole milk
150 ml	Heavy cream
30 g	Cornstarch
150 g	Sugar
15 g	Cocoa powder
3	Eggs, large
1/4 tsp	Salt
70 g	Bittersweet chocolate, chopped coarse

METHOD

1. Set a fine-mesh sieve over a large heatproof container and leave it standing ready.
2. Pour the milk and the cream into a medium saucepan with a heavy base. Bring them up to just short of a boil.
3. While the dairy heats, stir the cornstarch and sugar together in a mixing bowl, sift the cocoa powder over them, and whisk until the powder is evenly worked through.
4. Beat the eggs with the salt in a second bowl, tip them into the cocoa and sugar, and whisk to a smooth batter.
5. Pour roughly half the hot dairy into the egg mixture in a thin stream, whisking without pause the whole time.
6. Return the loosened egg mixture to the pan holding the remaining dairy. Cook over medium heat, whisking without stopping, until it has visibly thickened and reads 208F [98C] on a thermometer. Expect 5 to 7 minutes, longer if the eggs went in straight from the fridge.
7. Empty the pan through the sieve immediately.
8. Scatter the chopped chocolate over the hot custard and leave it to melt in the residual heat.
9. Once the chocolate has gone, run an immersion blender through the pudding for 5 full minutes, until not a lump is left. Stop as needed and scrape the sides of the container down with a rubber spatula.
10. A countertop blender in small batches does the same job, as does a whisk and patience. The mixture is near boiling, so handle it carefully either way.

NOTES

This is pastry cream in all but name. The thick set comes from the weight of chocolate stirred in at the end, which firms the custard as it cools, rather than from extra starch.
Adding hot liquid to eggs is tempering. Pour slowly or the eggs cook into threads instead of thickening.
Chase the thermometer, not the look. 208F [98C] is what gelatinises the cornstarch fully, and a custard that merely seems thick will loosen as it sits.
The 5 minutes of blending is what gives the texture. Cut it short and you can feel the grain.
Covered well, it keeps 4 days in the fridge. Eat it with unsweetened cream whipped to soft peaks, or use it to fill the chocolate pudding pie.

DATE ____ / ____ / ____ RATING ____ / 5 OVEN ADJ _____

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